

Lent And Saint Days

prc-lent-and-saint-days

Calendar & Customs · Holy Days · practice · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

breadth canon-wide
directness analogical
variants stable

Statement under examination

Lent, Ash Wednesday, and saint-days are not commanded by Scripture as observances binding on the Christian conscience; personal fasting and seasonal reflection remain commendable Christian disciplines apart from a calendar treated as obligatory.

In plain language

Two passages carry this question lexically. In Romans 14:5-6 Paul sets two believers side by side, one who esteems a day above others and one who treats every day alike, and tells each to be fully convinced in his own mind, using "to be fully persuaded" (plerophoreo) for full persuasion. Both the day-keeper and the non-keeper are said to act to the Lord and to give thanks to God, so the wording treats observance and non-observance as equally acceptable when done unto the Lord. In Colossians 2:16 a single command, let no one judge you, governs a chained list of food, drink, festival, new moon, and sabbaths, using "festival" (heorte), "new moon" (noumenia), and "sabbath" (sabbaton). Placing those calendar items under one negated "judging" (krino) removes them from the sphere where one believer may pass judgment on another. Verse 17 then calls them a shadow of the things to come, "a shadow of the things to come" (skia ton mellonton), while the body belongs to Christ, subordinating the calendar to its fulfillment. Hebrews 8:5 and 10:1 reuse the same "shadow" (skia) vocabulary for tabernacle and law, confirming a stable shadow-to-substance pattern. Taken together the wording supports the idea that fixed observances are not binding on conscience and that day-keeping is a matter of personal liberty. Fasting itself is assumed and regulated in Matthew 6:16-18 and practiced in Acts 13:2-3, so personal fasting and seasonal reflection are commendable in the wording, but no New Testament calendar prescribes them. Three limits keep this from being a flat reading. First, the New Testament names only first-century Jewish festal categories and never names Lent, Ash Wednesday, or saint-days, so those specific targets are reached only by analogy, and noumenia occurs just once in the New Testament, a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), so its scope cannot be triangulated. Second, Exodus 12:14 and Leviticus 23 show that under the prior covenant a calendar was in fact commanded, so the not-commanded claim holds on the New Testament side of the shadow to substance shift. Third, the negated judging in Colossians can be read as freely-permitted liberty, as a prescribed-observance exclusion of uncommanded worship, or as a corrupted-observance rebuke of imposed Judaizing, and the words alone do not decide among them. Because competing frameworks read the same data toward materially different conclusions, the lexical pattern leans toward liberty but is recorded as contested rather than settled.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G1035	βρώσις	brōsis	eating	
G1859	ἑορτή	heorte	festival	26
G2068	ἐσθίω	esthiō	to eat	
G2168	εὐχαριστέω	eucharistēo	to thank	48

G2250	ἡμέρα	hemera	day	392
G2919	κρίνω	krino	to judge	115
G3195	μέλλω	mellō	to ensue	
G3561	νουμηνία	noumenia	New Moon	1
G3563	νοῦς	nous	mind	24
G4135	πληροφορέω	plerophoreo	to fulfill	6
G4213	πόσις	posis	drink	
G4521	σάββατον	sabbaton	Sabbath	68
G4639	σκιά	skia	shadow	7
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5426	φρονέω	phroneo	to reason	30

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Colossians 2:16 places "festival" (heorte), "new moon" (noumenia), and "sabbath" (sabbaton) inside a single prohibition, "therefore let no one judge you" (me oun tis hymas krineto), so the lexical pattern places fixed calendar items in the category over which no one may pass judgment, and Colossians 2:17 classes them as "a shadow of the things to come" (skia ton mellonton) with the substance, "body" (soma), belonging to Christ. Romans 14:5-6 frames day-keeping as adiaphora (matters indifferent, neither commanded nor forbidden) where each is to be "let each be fully convinced in his own mind" (hekastos en to idio noi plerophoreistho), fully persuaded in his own mind, and both the day-keeper and the non-keeper act "to the Lord" (kyrio), and the eater "gives thanks" (eucharistei). The same "shadow" (skia) vocabulary recurs at Hebrews 8:5 and Hebrews 10:1 for tabernacle and law, reinforcing the typological (foreshadowing, where an earlier figure points forward to a later fulfillment) reading of the festal calendar. The texts name first-century Jewish festal categories and never name Lent, Ash Wednesday, or saint-days, so the proposition's specific targets are reached only by analogy, and "new moon" (noumenia) is a New Testament hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) at Colossians 2:16, so its single occurrence cannot triangulate scope. Competing readings, freely-permitted, prescribed-observance, and corrupted-observance, take the same data toward materially different conclusions, so the proposition is recorded as lexically disputed rather than plainly affirmed.

Scripture

Rom.14.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2250 ἡμέρα, G2919 κρίνω, G4135 πληροφορέω, G3563 νοῦς

Force. The clause "one esteems one day above another, another esteems every day alike" (hos men krinei hemeran par hemeran, hos de krinei pasan hemeran) sets two believers in deliberate contrast over day-esteeming, and the imperative "let each be fully convinced in his own mind" (hekastos en to idio noi plerophoreistho), let each be fully convinced in his own mind, locates the matter in the sphere of personal persuasion rather than a binding command. The verb "judge" or "esteem" (krino) here carries the sense of esteem or rank a day, not judicial condemnation.

Rom.14.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5426 φρονέω, G2250 ἡμέρα, G2168 εὐχαριστέω

Force. Both the one who "regards" (phronei) the day and the one who does not are said to act "to the Lord" (kyrio), and the eater "gives thanks to God" (eucharistei to theo). The lexical symmetry treats observance and non-observance as equally acceptable when done unto the Lord, which supports liberty rather than obligation in calendar matters.

Col.2.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2919 κρίνω, G1859 ἑορτή, G3561 νουμηνία, G4521 σάββατον

Force. The prohibition "therefore let no one judge you" (me oun tis hymas krineto) governs a chained list of food, drink, "in respect of a festival or new moon or sabbaths" (en merei heortes e noumenias e sabbaton), that is festival, new moon, or sabbaths. Placing "festival" (heorte), "new moon" (noumenia), and "sabbath" (sabbaton) under a single negated "judging" (krino) removes them from the sphere where one believer may pass judgment on another. "New moon" (noumenia) occurs only here in the New Testament (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), so its scope cannot be triangulated from other Pauline usage.

Col.2.17 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4639 σκιά, G4983 σῶμα, G3195 μέλλω

Force. The relative clause "which are a shadow of the things to come" (ha estin skia ton mellonton) classifies the festal calendar of verse 16 as a shadow of the things to come, with "but the body is of Christ" (to de soma tou Christou), but the body belongs to Christ. The "shadow" (skia) and "body" (soma) contrast subordinates the calendar to its fulfillment in Christ, which lexically grounds the claim that the observances are not themselves the binding substance.

Heb.8.5 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4639 σκιά

Force. Hebrews 8:5 uses the same "shadow" (skia) vocabulary for the earthly tabernacle service, "a copy and shadow" (hypodeigmati kai skia), copy and shadow of the heavenly things. The cognate use confirms a stable lexical pattern in which Old Testament ceremonial structure functions as "shadow" (skia) pointing to a heavenly substance, which is the same logic Colossians 2:17 applies to the festal calendar.

Heb.10.1 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4639 σκιά

Force. Hebrews 10:1 calls the law "a shadow of the good things to come, and not the very image of the things" (skian ton mellonton agathon, ouk auten ten eikona ton pragmaton), a shadow of the good things to come and not the very form, the same "shadow of the things to come" (skia ton mellonton) phrasing as Colossians 2:17. The recurring construction shows the festal calendar grouped with the law's typological (foreshadowing) shadow rather than treated as standalone perpetual ordinance.

Matt.6.16 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2250 ἡμέρα

Force. Jesus' instruction "moreover when you fast, do not be like the hypocrites" (otan de nesteuete, mh ginesthe os oi hypokritai) assumes that disciples will fast, regulating motive and posture rather than calendar. The wording is permissive of fasting practice while silent on prescribed seasons, which is the lexical seam where personal fasting is commendable but a binding calendar is not commanded.

Acts.13.2 · neutral · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2250 ἡμέρα

Force. "As they ministered to the Lord and fasted" (leitourgounton de auton to kyrio kai nesteuonton) describes Antioch elders fasting in worship without any fixed calendar warrant in the surrounding text. Acts shows fasting as a real church practice tied to seeking the Lord's direction, neither prescribed by a Christian calendar nor forbidden, matching the freely-permitted reading of the proposition.

Gal.4.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2250 ἡμέρα

Force. "You observe days and months and seasons and years" (hemeras paratereisthe kai menas kai kairous kai eniautous), you observe days and months and seasons and years, is rebuked as evidence of slipping back under "the elemental principles" (ta stoicheia), the elemental principles. The wording warns against re-imposing a calendar where Christ has set free, which strengthens the not-binding reading of fixed-day observance, though the target is specifically Judaizing imposition.

Exod.12.14 · complicates · genre: law

Key terms. G1859 ἑορτή

Force. The Passover is instituted as a memorial day to be kept as a feast forever, by an everlasting statute. As a complicating witness this shows that under the prior covenant a calendar day was indeed commanded and bound on conscience, so the proposition's not-commanded claim holds only on the New Testament side of the "shadow" (skia) and "body" (soma) transition named in Colossians 2:17.

Lev.23.1 · complicates · genre: law

Key terms. G1859 ἑορτή, G4521 σάββατον

Force. Leviticus 23 enumerates the appointed feasts as holy convocations commanded by God, the very festal categories Colossians 2:16 later names. This complicates a flat not-commanded reading because the calendar was commanded in its season, and supports the proposition only on the redemptive-historical (reading Scripture as one unfolding story of redemption across covenants) premise that these were shadow ordinances now fulfilled.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.14.6	Exod.12.14	tsk	1
Col.2.16	Lev.11.2	tsk	1
Col.2.16	Lev.16.31	tsk	1
Col.2.16	Lev.23.1	tsk	1
Col.2.16	Num.10.10	tsk	1
Col.2.17	Heb.8.5	tsk	1
Col.2.17	Heb.10.1	tsk	1
Rom.14.5	Gal.4.10	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Exod.12.14 · addressed

Passover is commanded as a perpetual statute under the Mosaic covenant, showing a calendar day once bound on conscience. Colossians 2:17 reclassifies such days as "a shadow of the things to come" (skia ton mellonton), shadow of the things to come, whose substance is Christ, so the not-commanded claim is restricted to the New Testament economy rather than denied of the prior covenant.

Lev.23.1 · addressed

The appointed feasts of Leviticus 23 are God-commanded holy convocations, the same "festival" (heorte) and "sabbath" (sabbaton) categories named in Colossians 2:16. They complicate any flat not-commanded reading; the proposition is sustained only on the premise that these were typological (foreshadowing) shadows now fulfilled, which is itself a contested framework judgment and a reason the verdict is recorded as disputed.

Col.2.16 · unaddressed

The negated "judging" (krino) in Colossians 2:16 can be read as freely-permitted liberty to observe or not observe, matching Romans 14, or as a prescribed-observance exclusion of uncommanded calendar acts, or as a corrupted-observance rebuke of Judaizing imposition specifically. The lexical data alone does not disambiguate which target the proposition's not-binding claim reaches, so this text is left unresolved and drives the disputed verdict.

Gal.4.10 · addressed

Paul rebukes observance of "days and months and seasons and years" (hemeras kai menas kai kairous kai eniautous) as enslavement to "the elemental principles" (ta stoicheia), but the targeted observance is Judaizing imposition. The text does not by its words decide whether a freely chosen non-mandatory Christian calendar falls under the same rebuke or under Romans 14 liberty, leaving the scope partly open.

Concordance traversed

G2250, G2919, G1859, G3561, G4521, G4639, G4983, G4135, G5426, G3563, G2168, G2068, G1035, G4213

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units supplied in the bundle for Romans 14:5-6 or Colossians 2:16-17. The marked surface forms in the bundle, such as the moveable position of "on the one hand" (men) and article variants, do not touch the festal vocabulary "festival" (heorte), "new moon" (noumenia), "sabbath" (sabbaton) or the "judging" (krino) prohibition, so no plausible reading alters the verdict. CBGM (the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a textual criticism technique for tracing manuscript relationships) is not in scope for these Pauline texts.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology, regulative_principle, normative_principle

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

freely_permitted_observance: affirms · Reads Romans 14:5-6 as paradigmatic adiaphora (matters indifferent, neither commanded nor forbidden) and Colossians 2:17 "shadow" (skia) and "body" (soma) as releasing the Mosaic calendar in Christ. Personal fasting and seasonal reflection are commendable per Matthew 6:16-18 and Acts 13:2-3, but no calendar binds conscience, so Lent, Ash Wednesday, and saint-days are uncommanded yet not forbidden when freely chosen and not imposed.

prescribed_observance_only: affirms · Holds that what Scripture does not command in worship is not to be bound; since Lent, Ash Wednesday, and saint-days are absent from the New Testament prescriptive data, they cannot be imposed on conscience, which converges on the proposition from the premise that worship requires positive command rather than mere permission.

corrupted_observance: disputed · Reads Colossians 2:16 and Galatians 4:10 as warning specifically against syncretistic or Judaizing calendars, and treats post-apostolic seasons that gather around veneration of saints or mandatory fasting as a parallel corruption. Under this lens the proposition's not-binding clause is granted, while the implicit acceptance of optional Lenten observance is contested as substantively corrupted rather than neutrally optional.

covenant_continuity: disputed · Distinguishes the ceremonial calendar abrogated in Colossians 2 from a perpetual moral sabbath principle, so the negated "judging" (krino) does not by itself settle whether any recurring holy day binds conscience; the calendar question remains partly open and the Lord's Day case is read separately.

The verdict turns on the redemptive-historical (reading Scripture as one unfolding story of redemption across covenants) move in Colossians 2:17 from shadow to substance and on the Romans 14 adiaphora (matters indifferent, neither commanded nor forbidden) frame. Whether the negated "judging" (krino) yields liberty, exclusion of uncommanded worship, or anti-corruption polemic is a framework decision the lexicon underdetermines, hence the divided lens verdicts. The three readings the hook names, prescribed-observance, freely-permitted, and corrupted-observance, are each represented in their strongest lexical form.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the New Testament lexical pattern command fixed annual or weekly calendar observances such as festivals, new moons, and sabbaths as obligations on the believer, or does it treat day-keeping as a matter of personal persuasion, and what does the festal vocabulary in Colossians 2:16-17 and Romans 14:5-6 indicate about their binding status?

The original stem embeds an evaluated framing through binding on the Christian conscience and a calendar treated as obligatory, which presupposes a position to be negated and pre-loads the liberty verdict. The neutralized form asks the lexical question without assuming the answer. The verdict was still derived against the original stem.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.2.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.14.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.10.1
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1859
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3561
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4639
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4135
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Col.2.17
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Col.2.16
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Col.2.17
syntax	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	Rom.14.6

License audit

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TSK	public_domain	yes
SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no

Flags

lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent · complicating-unresolved · ecm-shadow